

Left (top to bottom) Morning fish market, Hoi An, Vietnam; making roti by hand in Penang, Malaysia; neon-lit Chinatown in Bangkok, Thailand
Below (top to bottom) Curries and

toppings on sale at the evening market, Luang Prabang, Laos; *bak chor mee* (pork on egg noodles with chili peppers and vinegar) is served with a clear soup side-dish at Singapore's hawker stands



Little India Saturday Night Market

Masjid Jamek LRT, Kuala Lumpur

This bustling night market is the perfect place to try the Malay and Indian side of Malaysian street food. Don't miss satay and *apam balik*, thick pancakes with peanuts and corn.

SS2 Hawker Center

Petaling Jaya, Kuala Lumpur

The locals' favorite group of food stands is out of town but well worth the taxi ride. The Hawker Center has around 80 stands serving classics such as grilled stingray and *la la* (clams). The center's layout allows visitors to dine from as many stands as they wish and buy drinks from any of the many people that ply the aisles selling beverages.

LAOS

While Laos cannot compete with its larger neighbors for variety on the food front, there is still plenty to titillate the taste buds. The country's food takes influences from all its neighbors, and the setting can often be breathtaking.

Luang Prabang

The center of this city (a UNESCO World Heritage site) converts to a fabulous night market when evening falls. The air becomes thick with smoke, and banana leaves are piled high with delectable grilled meats. Try the *nem kao* (stuffed rice pancakes) or sticky rice with *sai gok* (local sausage).

SINGAPORE

Singapore is packed with street food, all of it inspected, regulated, and controlled for a degree of hygiene not seen elsewhere. Most of Singapore's 40,000 food stands are located inside "hawker centers."

Smith Street, Chinatown

Once a notorious red-light district, at night Smith Street is now home to many hawker stands. Look out for *char kway teow* (wok-fried noodles) and the sticky barbecued pork. Unusually for a food stand, China La Mian Steamed Buns makes a very delicious *xiao long bao* (juicy pork "small dragon" dumplings). For dessert, hunt out some *mochi*, little rice balls filled with crushed peanuts or sesame and served in pandan-leaf-flavored soup.

Little India, Rochor

Singapore's ethnic makeup is similar to Malaysia's trinity of cultures, and this area showcases the best of the Indian contingent's crafts and cuisine. The food stands here feature skillfully made *roti prata* (sweet flatbread), huge *dosai* (rice pancakes), and meals served on banana leaves.

Chinatown Complex Food Center

Trengganu Street

This is Singapore's largest hawker center, with more than 200 food stands. Favorites here include chicken rice, fried Hokkien prawn mee (fried noodles with shrimp), and claypot rice (chicken, Chinese sausage, and salted fish with crispy, lightly charred rice).

On the Menu

VIETNAM

Banh cuon Steamed and rolled-up rice-flour pancakes filled with pork and mushrooms, topped with fried shallots, and eaten with a spicy dipping sauce.
Banh mi French-style baguettes filled with meat and finished with pickled vegetables, herbs, and fiery pepper sauce.
Goi cuon A kind of Vietnamese spring roll: the rice paper roll holds pork, shrimp, rice noodles, herbs, and seafood.

THAILAND

Jo ke Rice porridge, which is common throughout this part of the world; in Thailand it is eaten for breakfast with minced pork and a soft egg.
Pad thai Tamarind and palm sugar

combine into the sweet-and-sour sauce of this well-known fried rice-noodle dish.
Som tam A salad of crunchy green papaya topped with fermented freshwater crab or jumbo shrimp, served with a lime and fish-sauce dressing.

MALAYSIA

Laksa The most famous of Nonya (Chinese Malay) dishes bathes rice noodles, meat, seafood, and vegetables in either stock (*asam laksa*; see pp204–5) or spiced coconut milk (curry laksa).
Pan mee Freshly rolled noodles served dry or in soup, topped with crisp fried anchovies and minced pork, and finished with a spoonful of chili pepper sauce.
Satay Tender meat kebabs that are marinated before grilling and served with a spice-rich dipping sauce.

SINGAPORE

Char kway teow Wide, flat, rice noodles (*ho fun*) stir-fried with meat, seafood, and egg. The chefs deftly toss the ingredients near the stove's flame, imparting *wok hei* – the essence of the wok – to the dish.
Chili crab A delicious but messy, chili-pepper-sauce-covered crab.
Claypot rice A mix of marinated chicken, waxed Chinese sausages, and salted fish cooked in a clay pot with rice over charcoal, so the rice develops a crunchy base, similar to Persian *chelo* (see p178), and a smoky flavor.
Roti prata These flatbreads arrived with southern Indian immigrants. Soft dough is deftly swung around the chef's head until it is paper-thin, then it is folded and fried into crisp layers. These are also sold all over Malaysia under the name *roti canai*.